

The Solo Founder's AI Stack

Agents run the company. These tools make the things it sells and says: the voice, the video, the images, the decks, the automations. The seven seats a one-person business fills with software in 2026, what each costs, and the order to buy them in.

The one-liner

The rest of this series is about agents that do work. This guide is about the other half of a one-person company: the tools that produce the voice, video, images, documents and plumbing a business needs to show up in the world.

The right way to think about them is as seats. A ten-person company has a voice-over artist, a video editor, a designer, a researcher, an operations person, a deck-builder and a developer. In 2026 a solo founder fills each of those seats with software for less than one of those people costs per day.

By the numbers — September 2026

7

seats a solo operation fills with software: voice, video, image, deck, research, automation, code

\$30–60

per month for a lean solo stack; \$150–300 for a small-team stack, per the operators who publish theirs

~\$90

what one five-day-a-week newsletter business reports spending on its whole AI stack, at \$25,000 a month in revenue

175+

languages a single video can be dubbed into with matching lip movement, in one pass

15+

generation models behind one all-in-one video platform, on one credit balance

15–20 hrs

per week solo operators typically report saving versus their pre-AI workflow

The seven seats

1. The voice — ElevenLabs

The standard for synthetic speech and the one tool on this list almost every solo creator names first. Text-to-speech that crosses the "I cannot tell" line for long-form audio, voice cloning from a short sample, and dubbing into dozens of languages with the timing preserved. For a solo creator it replaces a voice-over artist, a localisation agency and a sound designer. Starter is \$6 a month; the Creator tier at \$22 is where the quality most people mean by "ElevenLabs" begins. Its video and image features are secondary; buy it for the audio.

2. The video — Higgsfield, Runway, HeyGen

Three different jobs. Higgsfield is the all-in-one: fifteen-plus generation models, lip-sync, colour grading and ElevenLabs voice on a single credit balance, for people who want to make short video without juggling five subscriptions. Runway is the VFX seat — generation and editing with the most control, for anyone whose video is the product. HeyGen is the avatar seat — script in, a presenter on screen talking, dubbed into more than 175 languages with the lip movement matched, for explainers, sales videos and support content at scale. Most solo founders need one of the three, not all.

3. The images — a generation model plus a design tool

Image generation is now inside everything: ChatGPT, Gemini, Higgsfield, Canva. The practical seat is the design tool that turns a generated image into a thumbnail, an ad, a product mock-up or a social post with your brand on it. Canva remains the default for non-designers; Figma for anyone who wants precision. Midjourney is still the quality benchmark for standalone generation if you want a dedicated subscription.

4. The deck and the document — Gamma, plus your agent

Gamma turns a brief into a presentation, a one-pager or a landing page in minutes and, since its API went generally available, can generate them automatically from a CRM or a form. Cowork and ChatGPT Work produce finished decks and documents as a native output, which for many solo founders makes Gamma optional. Pick one; do not pay for both.

5. The research — Perplexity, or your agent's deep-research mode

Sourced, current answers with citations, for fact-checking, market research and competitor analysis. Perplexity Pro is the specialist; Claude, ChatGPT and Gemini each have a deep-research mode that covers most of the same ground on a plan you already pay for. The seat matters more than the brand: every claim you publish should have been checked by something that cites its sources.

6. The plumbing — Zapier or n8n, plus Lindy

Automation is what turns tools into a system. Zapier is the easiest: when a form is submitted, send it to Claude for classification, route it to the right database, notify you. n8n does the same, open-source and self-hosted, for anyone who wants to own the workflow. Lindy sits a level up: agents for inbox triage, meeting follow-ups and CRM hygiene that run without a trigger. This is the seat that stops a solo founder being the integration layer between all the

others.

7. The code — Claude Code or Codex

Covered in their own guides and listed here because the solo stack is not complete without it. A working tool, a landing page fix, a scraper, an internal dashboard: things that used to need a developer now come from a \$20 plan and a clear brief.

The stack at three budgets

Budget	Monthly	What is in it
Lean	\$30–60	One \$20 AI plan (Claude or ChatGPT, with its agent, deck and research modes), ElevenLabs Starter, Canva free, Zapier free tier
Working	\$100–150	The above plus ElevenLabs Creator, Higgsfield or HeyGen, Canva Pro, a paid Zapier or n8n
Producing	\$200–300	The above plus a second AI plan, Runway, Perplexity Pro, Lindy, a \$100 agent tier for heavy use

Start lean. Every seat above the first row is a seat you should be able to name the output of. "I make three videos a week" earns a video tool. "I might make videos" does not.

The order to buy in

1 — The \$20 AI plan first. It fills three seats — research, documents, code — and gives you an agent. Nothing else on this list matters until this is in daily use.

2 — Voice second, if you publish anything spoken. Podcasts, video, courses, multilingual anything. The gap between synthetic and real closed in 2025; the gap between good and free did not.

3 — Automation third. The moment you find yourself copying data between two tools, that is a Zap. Ten minutes to build, hours a month saved.

4 — Video only when you know the format. Avatar explainers, generated short-form, edited footage: three different tools. Pick after you have made ten videos the hard way and know which kind you make.

5 — Everything else when the output demands it. A design tool when the brand needs consistency. Research pro when citations are the product. A second AI plan when the first one's cap is the bottleneck.

The catches

- **Subscription creep.** Seven tools at \$20–50 each is a real salary. The operators who publish their stacks all say the same thing: consolidate, and audit quarterly.
- **Credit maths.** Video and voice platforms bill in credits, and dubbing, cloning and long generations consume them fast. Overage bills above the plan price are routine. Set the cap.
- **Voice rights.** Cloning a real person's voice needs their consent, documented. Your own voice is yours; a client's or a colleague's is not.
- **Generated does not mean good.** The tools make a competent draft of anything. The taste to know which draft to publish is still the solo founder's job, and the reason the business is worth anything.
- **The all-in-ones move fast.** Platforms that bundle fifteen models change models, prices and credits monthly. Do not build a workflow you cannot move.

How it fits with the agents

The agents in this series run the business: they research, code, email, sell, support and report. The stack in this guide is what the business shows to the world. In practice they meet in the middle. Cowork or a Polsia agent writes the script; ElevenLabs voices it; Higgsfield or HeyGen makes it a video; Zapier posts it and logs the result; an agent reads the numbers and drafts next week's script. One person, one afternoon a week, a production line.

Glossary

Stack — The set of tools a business runs on. A solo stack is one person's.

Seat — A role in a company, filled here by a tool rather than a hire.

Text-to-speech (TTS) — Generating spoken audio from written text. ElevenLabs is the benchmark.

Voice cloning — Reproducing a specific person's voice from a sample. Needs consent for anyone but yourself.

Dubbing — Translating spoken content into another language with matching audio, and increasingly matching lip movement.

Avatar video — A generated on-screen presenter reading a script. HeyGen, Synthesia.

Credits — The usage currency of most video and voice platforms. Watch the balance.

All-in-one platform — A service bundling many generation models behind one interface and one bill. Higgsfield is the best-known.

Automation — Software that moves data and triggers actions between tools. Zapier, n8n, Lindy.

Deep research — The mode in Claude, ChatGPT and Gemini that reads many sources and produces a cited report.

The stack makes the things. The agents run the company. Here is the rest.

GO DEEPER

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